

(d) Historical particularism

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The concept of Historical Particularism was given by Franz Boas as reaction to extreme diffusionism and ethnocentrism.

Key Concepts

- 1) He argued that evolution of any society is through different historical processes.
- 2) Hence, these societies must be studied from their viewpoint rather than making any generalizations.
- 3) He emphasized that only after one has done extensive fieldwork; then only any generalizations can be made.

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4) In his work 'Race, language and Culture'
gave the interpretational method to study
cultures.

5) During Baffin Island expedition, historical
particularism became the basis of
cultural relativism

6) It rejected the ethnocentric bias of many
anthropologists at that time.

Criticism ⇒ relied too much ~~data~~ on data
collection and led to redundancy in
theory formulation.

Despite all this, historical particularism led to
establishment of effective fieldwork and gave
rise to cultural relativism